

Cloze Test

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

A cloze test presents a full passage with multiple numbered blanks and asks you to pick the best word for each — the defining skill, unlike single-sentence fill-in-the-blank, is that context accumulates across the WHOLE passage, so a blank late in the passage may depend on information established two sentences earlier, and an early blank choice can constrain what a later blank must logically be. This sub-module covers reading the full passage before attempting any blank, distinguishing grammatical-word blanks (prepositions, articles, conjunctions) from vocabulary blanks, using surrounding sentences beyond the blank's own sentence, connector blanks that reflect the logical relationship between sentences, collocation-based elimination, maintaining consistent tone across all blanks, and the sequential dependency between blanks.

1. Read the Full Passage First

Never attempt the first blank immediately — read the entire passage once (skipping the blanks) to establish its topic, tone, and overall argument, since many blanks can only be resolved correctly once you know where the passage is heading.

- Passage: 'Remote work became widespread during the pandemic. Many companies initially saw it as a temporary (1)_____. However, as productivity data came in, several firms decided to make it a (2)_____ policy.' Reading fully first reveals the passage's arc — temporary became permanent — before guessing at either blank in isolation.

2. Grammatical-Word Blanks vs Vocabulary Blanks

Some blanks test structural words (prepositions, articles, conjunctions) where the correct choice depends purely on grammar rules, while others test content vocabulary where meaning and tone matter — identify which type each blank is before choosing an approach.

- 'The company decided _____ postpone the launch.' This blank needs the grammatical infinitive marker 'to' (decided TO postpone) — a fixed grammatical requirement, not a vocabulary choice.

3. Using Surrounding Sentences, Not Just the Blank's Own Sentence

A cloze blank's correct answer is often determined by a sentence BEFORE or AFTER the one containing the blank — reading only the blank's immediate sentence in isolation is a common cause of wrong answers.

- In the remote-work passage, blank (1) ('temporary _____') is only fully resolved once you read the next sentence ('as productivity data came in, several firms decided to make it a permanent policy') — this confirms blank (1) should be a word like 'measure' or 'arrangement', consistent with something that later became permanent.

4. Connector Blanks Reflect Sentence Relationships

When the blank itself is a connector ('however', 'therefore', 'in addition'), determine the logical relationship between the sentence containing the blank and the one before it — contrast, result, or additional point — exactly as with standalone fill-in-the-blank connector questions, but now anchored to the passage's established narrative.

- In the passage, the blank before 'as productivity data came in, several firms decided to make it a permanent policy' is preceded by 'many companies initially saw it as temporary' — the word 'However' fits this slot, marking the shift from initial assumption to the eventual reversal.

5. Collocation-Based Elimination

As with fill-in-the-blank, fixed word partnerships can eliminate options quickly within a cloze passage — check whether a candidate word for a blank forms a natural pairing with the fixed word next to it in the sentence.

- 'The firm decided to make it a _____ policy.' 'Permanent policy' is a natural, fixed-sounding collocation; an option like 'lasting policy' is grammatically fine but less standard, so 'permanent' is preferred when both are offered.

6. Maintaining Consistent Tone Across All Blanks

All blanks in a single passage should be filled with words that share a consistent register and tone with the rest of the (unblanked) text — a formal passage's blanks should all be filled with formal-register words, not a mix of formal and casual vocabulary.

- In a passage otherwise written in formal business language ('firms', 'productivity data', 'policy'), a blank should be filled with 'implement' rather than a more casual synonym like 'roll out', to keep the register consistent throughout.

7. Sequential Dependency Between Blanks

In multi-blank passages, an earlier blank's chosen word can constrain what a later blank logically must be — if blank 1 sets up a claim, blank 2 might need to support or contrast with it, so revisit earlier choices if a later blank doesn't fit any option comfortably.

- If blank (1) is filled with 'temporary measure' and blank (2) needs to describe the eventual policy, choosing 'permanent' for blank (2) is coherent only because blank (1) established the temporary-to-permanent arc — if blank (1) had instead been filled with 'failed experiment', blank (2) would need a very different, more negative word than 'permanent'.

Common Pitfalls

- Attempting the first blank immediately without reading the full passage to establish its overall topic and direction first.
- Resolving a blank using only its own sentence, missing a determining clue in an adjacent sentence.
- Filling a connector blank without checking whether the surrounding sentences show contrast, result, or continuation.
- Choosing a technically-correct word for a blank that breaks the passage's consistent formal or informal tone.
- Treating each blank as fully independent and missing how an earlier blank's answer constrains a later one.
- Ignoring fixed collocations in favor of a less natural but 'dictionary-correct' synonym.

Key Takeaways

- Always read the entire passage once before attempting any individual blank.
- Separate grammatical-word blanks (fixed by rule) from vocabulary blanks (fixed by meaning and tone) — they need different approaches.
- A blank's correct answer often depends on a sentence other than the one it sits in — read beyond the immediate sentence.
- Connector blanks require identifying contrast, result, or continuation between the surrounding sentences.
- Keep all blanks consistent with the passage's overall register — don't mix formal and casual vocabulary.
- Treat blanks as sequentially dependent — revisit an earlier choice if a later blank doesn't comfortably fit any option.

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